

NAPCS Unionization Research — State — Charter School Overview

Iowa — Dual jurisdiction: NLRB R33 (Track A) / Iowa PERA Iowa Code §20 (Track B)

Jurisdiction — June 6, 2026

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Section 1: State Overview

State	Iowa
Labor Board	Dual jurisdiction: NLRB R33 (Track A) / Iowa PERA Iowa Code §20 (Track B) — Track A (independently incorporated): National Labor Relations Board — Region 33, Peoria, Illinois. Track B (School Board Model): Iowa Employment Appeals Board (EAB, formerly PERB) administers Iowa PERA for district employees.
Governing Law	DUAL TRACK. Track A: National Labor Relations Act (NLRA) — Iowa Code §256E independently incorporated charter schools are private employers under NLRB R33. Track B: Iowa PERA (Iowa Code §20) — School Board Model (CSD*) charter school teachers are employees of the authorizing school district. Iowa school districts are public employers under Iowa Code §20.3. ISEA/NEA affiliates hold teacher agreements at virtually all Iowa districts. District teacher agreements cover CSD* charter school teachers by virtue of district employment.
Federal NLRB Jurisdiction	YES — NLRB R33 (Peoria) applies to Track A independently incorporated charter schools only. Track B School Board Model schools are covered by Iowa PERA, not NLRB.
Right-to-Work	Right-to-Work State — Iowa Code Ch. 731 (Iowa Right to Work Act) (Iowa has been right-to-work since 1947. Applies to Track A schools. Track B schools are public employers under Iowa PERA — RTW does not apply in the same way but Iowa PERA was significantly restricted in 2017 (mandatory subjects of bargaining limited to base wages only).)
For-Profit Operator Status	For-profit EMO management contracts permitted under state law
Card-Check Available	NO — Iowa is right-to-work (Iowa Code Ch. 731). Track A: NLRB jurisdiction — secret ballot election required. Track B: Iowa PERA — district-level teacher agreement, no school-specific election.
Registry Sweep	COMPLETE — June 2026 — 10 charter schools searched
Research Window	June 2026

Section 2: Charter School Landscape

Total charter schools in Iowa: 10 (Iowa Department of Education Authorized Charter Schools List (March 2026), educate.iowa.gov. 10 currently open schools: 3 School Board Model (CSD*) + 7 independently incorporated. 5 additional schools authorized but not yet open (2 CSD* models + 3 independent) — excluded from research universe per PDR-013 zero-organized state protocol.). Unionization census figures reflect confirmed organized schools as of the data currency date.

Category	Schools	% of Total	Notes
DEPENDENT — Iowa PERA (School Board Model)	3	30% of universe	Hamburg Charter HS (Hamburg CSD), Storm Lake/Iowa Central/BVU Early College HS (Storm Lake CSD), West Central Charter HS (West Central CSD). District employment → Iowa PERA → ISEA/NEA teacher agreement coverage.
No Organizing Activity Documented (Track A)	7	70% of universe	All 7 independently incorporated IA charter schools. NLRB R33. RTW state. Young charter school community (2022–2025)

			openings). Zero NLRB petitions.
TOTAL	10	100%	

Charter School Enrollment

Total Charter Enrollment	804 students — 0.2% of state K–12 enrollment (504,292 total K–12 students)
Students in CMO/EMO-Affiliated Charter Schools	150 students in network-affiliated schools — 18.7% of total charter enrollment
Students in Organized Charter Schools	205 students (25.5% of charter enrollment)
Data Sources	Charter enrollment: NCES ELSI 2024–25 / Charter School Registry v133. Total K–12 state enrollment: NCES ELSI 2024–25 (all public schools). Both figures from the same source and year.

Section 3: Charter Management Organizations & Education Management Organizations

Charter Management Organizations (CMOs) are nonprofit networks. Education Management Organizations (EMOs) are for-profit management companies. Data sourced from Charter School Registry v133. Union penetration reflects confirmed organized schools as of the data currency date.

CMO / EMO Name	Type	State Campuses	National Campuses †	Organized in State	Total Enrollment
Concept Schools	Network‡	1	—	—	150
TOTAL — All CMO/EMO Schools in Iowa		1		—	150
of which organized				—	—

Total enrollment shown is the combined enrollment of all CMO/EMO network schools in Iowa. Organized network schools: 0 organized schools in network-affiliated charters.

† National Campuses reflects total campuses operated by this network across all states, as reported in Charter School Registry v133. Provides context for networks operating in multiple states.

‡ Network (type unclassified) = operator present in Charter School Registry v133 but not yet classified in CMO Reference data. Contact registry project to add classification for these records.

1 network (type unclassified). Approximately 9 schools operate independently with no CMO/EMO affiliation. Source: Charter School Registry v133.

Section 4: Legal Framework & Charter School Overview

Findings are based on research as of June 6, 2026.

1: Legal & Jurisdictional Framework DUAL TRACK. Track A: National Labor Relations Act (NLRA) — Iowa Code §256E independently incorporated charter schools are private employers under NLRB R33. Track B: Iowa PERA (Iowa Code §20) — School Board Model (CSD*) charter school teachers are employees of the authorizing school district. Iowa school districts are public employers under Iowa Code §20.3. ISEA/NEA affiliates hold teacher agreements at virtually all Iowa districts. District teacher agreements cover CSD* charter school teachers by virtue of district employment. Iowa is a right-to-work state (Iowa Code Ch. 731 (Iowa Right to Work Act)). Charter schools in Iowa are subject to NLRB jurisdiction as private employers (Dual jurisdiction: NLRB R33 (Track A) / Iowa PERA Iowa Code §20
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(Track B)). Secret ballot NLRB election is the required organizing pathway. Card-check is not available.

2: Charter School Structure

Iowa operates 10 open-enrollment charter schools, enrolling approximately 804 students. 1 charter management organizations and education management organizations operate in Iowa. The largest networks by campus count are Concept Schools (1 campuses in state). Approximately 9 schools operate independently with no CMO or EMO affiliation. Network-level detail, including campus counts and total enrollment, appears in Section 3 above.

Section 5: Media Coverage & Public Stakeholder Positions

Legislative Context

Collective bargaining for Iowa public employees is governed by the Public Employment Relations Act, Iowa Code ch. 20, administered by the Iowa Public Employment Relations Board. Amendments enacted in 2017 narrowed mandatory subjects of negotiation to base wages for most bargaining units, excluded subjects including evaluation procedures and staff reduction, and established periodic recertification elections for certified units. Iowa is a right-to-work state; agency fees are not collected. The Iowa State Education Association, the NEA state affiliate, serves as the negotiating representative in most Iowa school districts and maintains a public affiliate structure of local associations. Where charter school staff are employed by a school district, the district's negotiated agreement is the operative instrument governing terms and conditions of employment.

Section 6: Contract & CBA Access Registry

Dual jurisdiction: NLRB R33 (Track A) / Iowa PERA Iowa Code §20 (Track B) public contracts portal. Direct PDF links may require a records request for full text.

School / Network	Union	CBA Status & Term	Contract Access
Hamburg Charter High School			N/A
Storm Lake/Iowa Central/BVU Early College High School			N/A
West Central Charter High School			N/A